

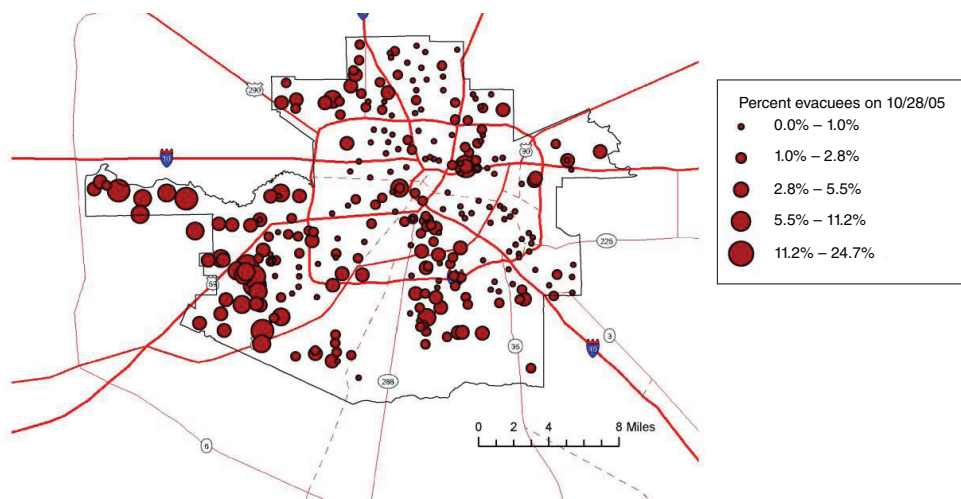


FIGURE 1. HURRICANE KATRINA AND RITA EVACUEES IN HISD BY SCHOOL, 2005–2006

in schools based on their location of residence at the time. In fact, because the McKinney-Vento Homeless Education Assistance Act of 2001 requires states to enroll homeless students, schools were forced to promptly enroll the evacuees. Once enrolled, the McKinney-Vento Act also prohibits segregating homeless students from the general population. Hence, evacuees had to be included in classes with nonevacuee students.⁹ Even if schools wanted to separate students by academic level, they had little information on the students upon enrollment. According to a superintendent in Baton Rouge, most paperwork was unavailable or destroyed in the flooding, so placement was based on parents' verbal information. Due to the unusual circumstances, both Texas and Louisiana waived requirements on immunization and academic records for evacuees.¹⁰

Figure 1 displays a map of the percentage of Katrina and Rita student evacuees in HISD schools, which shows substantial variation in terms of exposure to the evacuee children. Some schools in Houston received no evacuees at all, while the mean and maximum shares were 2.5 percent and 25 percent of students by late October, 2005. Figure 2 shows a similar map for Louisiana. Like Houston, some schools in Louisiana received no evacuees at all, while the average and largest evacuee enrollments in our analysis sample, which excludes schools in the areas directly affected by the storms and schools with more than 70 percent evacuees, were 3.1 percent and 56 percent, respectively.

It is important to point out that our empirical analysis below does not rely on the cross-sectional variation in the share of evacuees in Houston and Louisiana shown

⁹ Figures 1 and 2 in the online Appendix show that evacuees in Houston were distributed widely across classrooms. While we do not have classroom data for students in Louisiana, we are able to identify the teacher who administered the standardized tests as a proxy for classroom or homeroom teacher. Figure 3 in the online Appendix shows that in Louisiana evacuees were dispersed widely across test administrators as well.

¹⁰ The Texas Education Agency (TEA) website states that "standard immunization requirements for children attending school in Texas are being temporarily waived for children displaced by Hurricane Katrina," and the same was true of student records. <http://texaslawhelp.org/tx/showdocument.cfm/doctype/dynamicdoc/ichannelprofileid/27884/idynamicdocid/3109/iChannelID/91/foreignlanguage/1>.